

Platformized domestic labor beyond technology: “Uncaring by design”?

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ABSTRACT

Platform studies have increasingly emphasized everyday life as central to researching how gig labor platforms have seemingly evolved into urban infrastructures that connect the demand and supply of services. This paper takes the emphasis on everyday life seriously, locating the rise of platforms mediating domestic services within longer histories of feminized, migrantized, and informal domestic work in Continental Europe. This encompasses the perspectives of platform clients and the undercurrents that emerge between workers and clients following the digital mediation of domestic services, specifically within the private sphere of the home. In doing so, we propose a shift in focus from digital platforms as such to the embodied and affective encounters and expectations that underpin platform-mediated domestic work. Against this backdrop, we approach marketplace platforms that mediate domestic cleaning services in view of interpersonal relationships between cleaners and clients, highlighting how platforms mediate gigs while relying on workers' subject positions shaped by migrantized, gendered, and classed embodiments. We zoom in on Austrian care platforms by combining empirical insights from interviews with cleaners and clients, which are presented as composite vignettes and supplemented with insights from interviews with platform managers. Moreover, we offer a critical feminist reading of the platformization of domestic service labor and the underlying power hierarchies. Hence, we build on the observations that domestic work has gained political momentum through its platformization and yet continues to be devalued along gendered, classed, and migrantized embodiments – and due to its location at home.

1. Introduction

In recent years, platform labor has evolved from being framed as a digital innovation to being recognized as an infrastructural component of urban life (Barns, 2019; Berfelde & Kluzik, 2022; Van Doorn, 2022; Zampoukos et al., 2024). For example, this notion is evident in the realm of domestic service platforms, which mediate ‘dirty work’ in both figurative and literal senses. The former refers to precarious working conditions, while the latter refers to tasks such as cleaning dirt in other people's homes. Far from merely facilitating gig work, these platforms actively reorganize social reproduction by reshaping the conditions under which cleaning labor is demanded, delivered, and experienced (Rodríguez-Modroño, Agenjo-Calderón, & López-Igual, 2022; Strüver, 2024; Van Doorn, 2017).

While much of the platform labor scholarship has focused on technological affordances, algorithmic control, and gig workers' precarity (Vallas & Schor, 2020; Woodcock & Graham, 2020), less attention has been paid to (1) the role of clients—their motivations and experiences,

and (2) the interpersonal dynamics that unfold between cleaners and clients after digital mediation within the private sphere of the home, where the service occurs. As a result, we propose a shift in focus from digital platforms to social, embodied, and affective encounters, which form the basis for domestic gig work as an emerging urban infrastructure.

Feminist and critical scholars have long argued that domestic work captures a contradictory position within capitalist societies: it is essential yet devalued, commodified yet affective labor (Federici, 2019, 2020; Fraser, 2016, 2022; Weeks, 2011). With the rise of platform-mediated cleaning in countries like Austria, these contradictions have persisted and become further complicated, as platforms have introduced a third party into what was previously a dyadic and often informal relationship between the client and the cleaner. These platforms have employed algorithmic matchmaking, subscription fees, workers' online profiles, and clients' reviews to shape who earns gigs (including where and when) and how domestic workers must present themselves—typically as competent, flexible, responsible, and welcoming providers of domestic

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services. While platforms promise convenience and efficiency for clients, they impose new burdens on workers, including 24/7 availability and photo curation, as well as navigating clients' opaque expectations and the risk of abuse (see, e.g., Gruszka et al., 2024; Pulignano et al., 2023; Wiesböck & Radlherr, 2025).

In what follows, our focus is on digital platforms mediating cleaning tasks in Austria via a marketplace model. This model relies less on algorithmic management to mediate work and workers than on ranking a large pool of workers and making their online profiles visible (Ticona et al., 2018). Regarding the latter, we do not consider these platforms to be neutral mediators but active participants in shaping offline encounters that reinforce and reproduce structural power asymmetries. Drawing on 28 interviews with cleaners, clients, and managers of two platforms mediating domestic cleaning in Austria, we present our analysis as condensed composite vignettes to elucidate how these power asymmetries are experienced, negotiated, and internalized both online and offline. These synthesized narratives allow us to move beyond abstract critiques of platform labor and to foreground interpersonal dynamics between cleaners and clients without looking for and relying on “quotes that ‘fit’” (Bissell, 2023, p. 193) to the thematic framework and theoretical assumptions. We will use these vignettes to dive into the broader question of whether it is digital platforms that are “uncaring by design” (adopted from Chatzidakis et al., 2020, p. 7) or domestic labor as such that is challenging. The latter will be addressed in more detail by asking how cleaners and clients experience each other within their affective, embodied encounters in the intimate space of the home and to what extent these encounters are shaped by broader structures of patriarchal and neoliberal capitalism.

We thus respond to the insight that the scholarship on domestic service and care platforms has largely neglected the reorganization of social reproduction and the role of clients within it. Indeed, critical urban and feminist platform studies have increasingly conceptualized labor platforms as urban infrastructures that mediate the supply and demand for domestic services, which implicates clients in these processes (Bauriedl & Strüver, 2020, 2022). For example, while some have argued that gig workers may “free up time” for clients “in need” due to time constraints or lifestyle preferences (Rodríguez-Modroño, 2024; Zampoukos et al., 2024), others have viewed platform use as more clearly driven by a “domestic time squeeze” and a coping strategy for time-pressed single parents and dual-earner households (Huws, 2019; Piletić, 2024). Therefore, this vagueness surrounding clients' motivations for using platforms to mediate cleaning tasks, among other aspects emphasized below, has motivated this paper (for similar claims in the context of platform-mediated domestic services, see Gerold et al., 2025; Pignolo, 2025; Strüver & Gatsinos, 2025).

By framing domestic cleaning platforms as “uncaring by design,” we do not suggest a failure of technology but rather seek to illuminate the structural logics underpinning both the platforms and the broader political economy of care relations and social reproduction. This paper thus contributes to ongoing debates in feminist political economy, platform urbanism, and labor geography by insisting that the digital mediation of domestic tasks must be understood through the lens of embodied inequalities and needs to link micropolitics to capitalism as a social structure.

Sections 2 and 3 provide a brief introduction to the Austrian context of domestic service labor and the recent changes brought about by digital platforms that mediate this labor. Subsequently, Section 4 introduces the methodology, while Section 5 pays special attention to composite vignettes based on interviews with clients and workers. Section 6 then presents a discussion on platform-mediated offline encounters between clients and cleaners, followed by a brief outlook on future research (Section 7). We stress that digital platforms mediating domestic service labor such as cleaning are less disruptive as often argued, but they must be analyzed within the long history of feminized, migrantized, and informal domestic labor in Europe. Hence, platform-mediated cleaning is a continuation—albeit intensified—of historical

patterns of social inequalities and exploitation related to social reproduction.

2. Domestic work as a service and platform-mediated domestic cleaning

Across Europe, the combination of increasing female labor force participation and the intensification and flexibilization of paid work puts households under pressure to balance their domestic and care obligations. Feminist scholars have argued that this issue is part of a broader crisis of social reproduction and care in capitalist societies (Dowling, 2021, 2022; Fraser, 2016, 2022; Huws, 2019). One response has been the outsourcing of some of these tasks, especially domestic cleaning, for those who can afford it (Estevez-Abe & Hobson, 2015; Hester & Srnicek, 2023). Thus, what was once conducted mainly within the private home by women in their roles as housewives and mothers has increasingly been externalized and marketized as a commodified service—and the mediation of domestic cleaning through digital platforms is a dominant manifestation of this commodification.

This shift, however, has not transformed the symbolic and material hierarchies that structure domestic labor. Despite its growing marketization, domestic cleaning continues to occupy an ambivalent position between paid employment and moralized duty (Näre, 2011), reflecting enduring gendered and classed assumptions about whose time, bodies, and care are valued. Societal perceptions of domestic cleaning further entrench its marginalization (Gruszka et al., 2022; Wiesböck et al., 2023). This work is simultaneously necessary and unremarkable, often framed as a feminine duty or obligation, which obscures its socioeconomic value and reinforces its invisibility (Federici, 2019, 2020; Fraser, 2022). When performed in one's home, this work is often interpreted as intimate care or affective labor. However, when performed in another's home, the work must conform to the household's expectations while remaining institutionally unprotected (Anderson, 2007; Näre, 2011). These contradictory meanings between care and labor, as well as intimacy and service, make domestic cleaning a paradigmatic example of how social reproduction is feminized, commodified, and devalued at the same time.

Moreover, domestic cleaning and other types of care work entangled with social reproduction at home are one of the most ancient forms of informal work and digital labor platforms thus “fit perfectly in an informal, devalued, and precarious care sector” (Rodríguez-Modroño, Ajenjo-Calderón, & López-Igual, 2022, p. 624; see also Bor, 2021; De Vita & Bertolini, 2025). Indeed, domestic care service work has a much longer tradition of informal work than other location-based platform services, yet research on platform-mediated domestic services is not as pervasive as that on ride-hailing or food delivery. Nevertheless, since the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic in Spring 2020 and the resulting initial ban on services in homes beyond one's own, research on domestic care services (e.g., childcare, eldercare, and cleaning) has increased significantly. This is due to observing that the pandemic also drove the demand for and commodification of domestic care work (Bauriedl & Strüver, 2022; Schilliger et al., 2023)—and, in general, that platforms promise a flexible and fast solution for individual domestic time crunches (Dowling, 2022; Huws, 2019; Lentz et al., 2025). Individual care crises however are entwined with the societal care crisis, which Chatzidakis et al. (2020) have identified as an effect of neoliberal capitalism that places profit over people. Its uncaring design thus hollows out caring activities, reduces invisible and undervalued care labor to exploitative market logics and platforms mediating domestic care services are an exemplary outcome of neoliberal capitalism as they “capitalise on the very crisis they have helped to create” (ibid., p. 8; see also Fraser, 2022).

However, a disagreement exists about whether the mediation of domestic tasks via platforms alters this type of work (e.g., Altenried, 2024; Piletić, 2024; Ticona et al., 2018). Scant research has investigated the actual working relationships between clients and workers, as well as

how they change when mediated by a platform. Although we approach platforms mediating domestic services such as cleaning as digital infrastructures, we focus on these services as embodied care infrastructures while considering the interpersonal and affective relations they entail.

But first we acknowledge platforms' means to *make* markets (Koutsimpogiorgos et al., 2023) and, thus, their power to disrupt the traditional mediation of existing relationships between clients and workers among family and friends (see, e.g., Kampouri, 2022). While they rely on technological innovations (e.g., apps' affordances, digital matchmaking, and control) and alter both workers' and clients' everyday lives, they revive the notorious association of social reproduction with unpaid work and female domesticity or informal, underpaid domestic labor. Therefore, "digital labor platforms that enter the care industry [sic] become a technology-enabled, capital-driven force in the larger commodification and exploitation process of ... reproductive labor" (Yin, 2024, p. 120). They rely on institutional neoliberal essentials such as privatization, individualization, deregulation, flexibilization and precarization on the one hand and institutionalized social structures such as racism, patriarchy and discriminatory migration and labor policies on the other (Vallas & Schor, 2020; Yin, 2024; see also Fraser, 2022). However, Aleksandra Piletić (2024, p. 442-445) argued that platforms *perpetuate* these neoliberal developments while disrupting the existing modes and *relationships* of social reproduction since they commodify and outsource key reproductive tasks such as cleaning and childcare.

Platforms thus extract profit from previously informal markets and informal relationships due to their power to intensify the commodification of activities related to social reproduction and domestic care and to blur the boundaries between production (i.e., the public market) and social reproduction (i.e., private households). Zooming in on platform-mediated domestic cleaning in Austria while considering research findings on workers' lived experiences at the micro-level from other areas in Continental Europe (Altenried & Niebler, 2024; Bor, 2021; Floros & Jørgensen, 2022; Keller, 2022, 2023; Koutsimpogiorgos et al., 2023; Niebler & Animento, 2023; Pignolo, 2023, 2025; Piña et al., 2024; Pulignano et al., 2023; Rodríguez-Modroño, 2024; Rodríguez-Modroño, Ajenjo-Calderón, & López-Igual, 2022; Rodríguez-Modroño, Pesole, & López-Igual, 2022; Strüver, 2024), this paper is not motivated by discussing yet another local case study. Instead, the question is whether *platform-mediated* domestic labor or *platform-mediated domestic labor* is "uncaring by design" at the macro level, which manifests in social alienation and economic devaluation. Before turning to this question through composite vignettes of platform-mediated relationships between cleaners and clients in Austria as micropolitical experiences below, we briefly summarize the historical development of domestic service work in Continental Europe prior to and as effects of the changes tied to digital technology.

3. The continental European and Austrian context of domestic service work and platformization

Historically, domestic care services have always been primarily informal, invisible, feminized, and racialized/migrantized—and have not been recognized as genuine labor beyond social reproduction (Federici, 2019). Domestic care is particularly tied to gender norms, especially to notions of female subjectivities and their assumed caring personalities (Weeks, 2011). While these dynamics are observable across Europe, their specific articulation depends on national welfare regimes, labor market structures, and migration patterns. In Austria, these dynamics are particularly pronounced. The post-war consolidation of the male-breadwinner model embedded expectations that women would provide the bulk of domestic work, reinforced by tax, welfare, and education policies that assumed female domesticity as a normative ideal (Esping-Andersen, 2009; Lutz & Palenga-Möllnbeck, 2015; Obaro, 2012). Only from the late twentieth century did rising female

labor force participation and growing household time pressures generate renewed demand for externalizing domestic cleaning.

Nevertheless, this demand has not led to the widespread formalization of the domestic cleaning sector (Sardadvar, 2019; Stadler, 2020). Instead, a bifurcated labor market has emerged, with formal mechanisms, such as service vouchers and occasional agency contracts, coexisting alongside a pervasive cash-in-hand economy (Obaro, 2012). Whereas formal contracts offer limited protections, the majority of work remains informal—eroding social insurance coverage, labor rights, and the bargaining power of cleaners (Sardadvar, 2019; Stadler, 2020). Formal employment contracts, where they exist, are often part-time, fragmented, and accompanied by unpaid travel and waiting periods. Yet, informal arrangements often leave workers without access to sick pay, health and accident insurance, or pensions. Physical demands are high, while social and psychological burdens, including isolation, stigma, and discretionary power exercised by clients, compound the precarity (Stadler, 2020; Triandafyllidou, 2016).

Although reliable data on the informal cleaning workforce in Austria remain scarce, available research and statistics on the formal sector indicate that domestic cleaning reflects entrenched structural inequalities. The work is predominantly performed by migrant women, with many cleaners being recent migrants from Eastern Europe and the Balkans (Bauer et al., 2014; Stadler, 2020). Households that outsource cleaning are typically middle-class or professional families seeking to reconcile employment demands with domestic responsibilities. This issue creates a clear cross-class division: affluent households purchase time and buy services, while marginalized migrant women supply the labor under conditions of precarity (Anderson, 2007; Parreñas, 2003).

While in its early stages, platform-mediated care work has supposedly challenged the classification of such work as precarious and informal (Hunt & Machingura, 2016; Koutsimpogiorgos et al., 2023; Rodríguez-Modroño, 2024), the character of informality and the interdependencies of inequalities along the lines of gender, race/migration, and class continue to be prerequisites for this type of work and are nowadays intensified by platforms (Bauriedl & Strüver, 2020, 2022; Rodríguez-Modroño, 2024; Vogel & Köszegi, 2023). Platforms attract marginalized populations (e.g., women and migrants) and place them in precarious, insecure work that lacks social protection. Traditional forms of matching cleaners with households—through family and friends—have been prevalent in Austria for a long time (see, e.g., Gutiérrez-Rodríguez, 2014; Prattes, 2019), the emergence of digital platforms mediating gigs has transformed both the initial contact and the relationship between clients and workers from a dyadic exchange and word-of-mouth referrals into a triangular structure that incorporates clients, workers, and platforms, with the latter exacerbating the precariousness of the working relationship (see Flanagan, 2019 for an early assessment of the Australian gig economy). While digital mediation downright simplifies the process of matching cleaners with clients, it obscures previous ways of establishing mutual trust and respect as central elements of these kinds of relationships, where work is conducted in private homes and often remains informally remunerated.

Hence, these platforms reproduce macro-level inequalities through the micropolitical mechanisms of digital mediation (Rodríguez-Modroño, Pesole, & López-Igual, 2022) in at least four ways:

First, the platformization of care services has increasingly supplemented the informal private networks of mediation through family and friends—among clients as well as workers—with formal digital mediation, with both forms coexisting. Indeed, platforms are gaining growing prominence, with *Care.com* being by far the largest and oldest platform mediating domestic care services worldwide and also in Continental Europe (Ticona et al., 2018). Nevertheless, formalized mediation has not resulted in formal employment, whether by the platform or the client. Instead, it has introduced a third party into this relationship that provides digital infrastructure in the form of an online marketplace for paid brokerage (i.e., subscription-based) without an infrastructure of employed workers. Therefore, cleaners must work for the platform for

free by setting up their profiles, keeping them up to date, and responding to requests 24/7 (Keller, 2022, 2023; Pulignano et al., 2023; Wiesböck et al., 2023; Wiesböck & Radlherr, 2025). Platforms like Care.com (and the Austrian division thereof, betreut.at) digitally connect private households (i.e., clients) with cleaners while positioning themselves as ‘neutral’ intermediaries that extract fees and data and mediate reputations. This triangular form diffuses accountability, blurs responsibilities, hinders workers’ solidarization, and transforms ‘employment’ into a triadic commercial relationship entrenched in atomization and informality due to cleaners’ status as independent contractors (Altenried & Niebler, 2024; Niebler & Animento, 2023). Finding a cleaner in contemporary Austrian households thus no longer depends solely on personal recommendations or networks, as digital marketplace platforms have started to offer access to domestic workers ‘the easier way’. They present clients with profiles, photos, and reviews of a seemingly endless supply of cleaners while promising access to flexible, reliable, and pre-vetted domestic help (Gruszka et al., 2024; Lentz et al., 2025).

Second, in the marketplace platform model, clients hold disproportionate power over cleaners. Ratings and reviews directly influence workers’ access to future cleaning gigs, but workers cannot respond to negative feedback or rate clients, which reinforces this uneven dynamic (Gruszka et al., 2022; Wiesböck et al., 2023). Moreover, due to the anonymity of digital mediation, the offline encounters of cleaners with their clients encompass higher risks of disrespect, microaggression, physical abuse, and sexual harassment (Lentz, 2025; Wiesböck & Radlherr, 2025). Therefore, workers are transformed from providing a service to *becoming* the service (Prassl, 2018).

Third, the latter obscures how platforms and clients deal with cleaners as embodied—yet invisible—infrastructure (Berfelde & Kluzik, 2022; Striver, 2024; Van Doorn, 2022; Zampoukos et al., 2024), a rather uncaring treatment tied to gendered, racialized/migrantized, and classed inequalities, as well as ways of exploitation that have been foundational parts of patriarchal capitalism long before platformization. Rodríguez-Modroño et al. (2024) further argued that platforms capitalize on the long-standing undervaluation of social reproductive work—and of female and migrant workers in this sector—by leveraging long-standing institutional and structural inequalities to commodify domestic work with minimal protection and to continue prior exploitation patterns.

Fourth, platforms mediating domestic care services in cities challenge the predominant notions of platform *urbanism*. Platform urbanism is concerned with the co-constitutive relationship between platforms and cities and as a concept explicates how platforms take over the organization of public urban life. As analytical term, platform urbanism is understood as a special mode of using and producing urban spaces—a mode that transforms the relational dynamics between code, commerce, and corporealities by way of capitalizing urban spaces (Barns, 2019; Leszczynski, 2020; Sadowski, 2020). However, with respect to domestic service labor, we must go beyond the affordances of platform technologies, workers’ experiences and new spatial patterns in cities in order to investigate domestic—and thus private—spaces as part of the ‘public’ urban. This is a void in platform research, just like the investigation of offline relationships between workers and clients in private spaces.

4. Methodology and methods

The structure of triangular labor relationships among platforms, clients, and cleaners echoes traditional intermediation but with distinctly digital facets: platforms extract subscription fees, mediate reputation, and shift responsibilities for work and pay onto cleaners and clients without protecting workers by verifying clients’ accountability. Hence, the relationship appears to be tied to the digital infrastructure (i.e., the platform) that reproduces the exploitation of workers as *embodied* infrastructure. By way of ‘mirroring’ this triangular relationship, we bring the three parties involved (i.e., the platform, clients, and workers) together in our analysis. We do not rely on quotes of individual

interviews (Bissell, 2023) but on condensed “composite vignettes” (Claeys et al., 2025) of workers and clients. The subsequent discussion aims to ‘confront’ these vignettes with findings from interviews with platform managers who advertise their service as neutral mediation that ‘helps’ both clients and cleaners.

We draw our insights from 28 semi-structured interviews conducted in Vienna (Austria) between 2023 and 2025: 21 with (migrant) women working as cleaners, five with clients booking cleaning via two marketplace platforms, betreut.at and haushaltshilfe24.at,¹ and two with platform representatives.² The focus of the conversations differed slightly across groups. Cleaners’ questions centered on their working experiences, including everyday practices, the embodied and affective dimensions of cleaning, and encounters with clients and platforms. The clients’ focus was on expectations, hiring practices, and experiences with domestic workers in the private sphere of their homes. Platform representatives’ interviews explored how their platforms worked, as well as their business models and perceived roles within the domestic service sector.

The interviews lasted between 45 min and 2 h and were conducted in German or English, depending on the participants’ language proficiency and preferences. All interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed verbatim, and pseudonymized to protect the participants’ identities. Given that most interviewees were migrant women working under precarious and predominantly informal conditions, ethical considerations were central throughout the research process. Particular attention was paid to informed consent, confidentiality, and the avoidance of any risk related to participants’ legal or work status. Interviews were conducted in locations chosen by participants, and interviewees were free to decline questions or withdraw at any point.

Accordingly, the research acknowledges power asymmetries between researchers and participating workers, shaped by differences in class position, citizenship status, and academic authority. These asymmetries informed both the recruitment strategy of cleaners and the interview setting. The decision to avoid recruitment through official platform channels and to communicate transparently via a client’s profile clearly identifiable as research-driven instead as well as to encourage off platform contact was not only an ethical precaution but also a methodological choice shaped by an awareness of workers’ vulnerability to surveillance and sanction (Bor, 2022; Orth & Baum, 2024). During the interviews, this awareness manifested in a cautious, participant-led approach that allowed cleaners to control the pace, focus, and limits of their narratives. The trust placed in the researchers by the cleaners was taken seriously and, in some cases, extended beyond the formal interview context, with participants continuing to share stories and experiences via WhatsApp for several months after the interview. For the same reasons, we compensated cleaners financially for their time, recognizing the value of their labor and the demands of participation.

Even though the power imbalances in the interview setting between clients and researchers are not quite as pronounced, the approach of transparency-led feminist, power-sensitive interview recruiting and interviewing was the same. Nevertheless, recruiting clients for interviews was the biggest challenge in our research process and required reaching out via various social media channels, neighborhood forums, local community groups, and personal networks, as direct outreach via

¹ Both platforms operate internationally: betreut.at is the Austrian branch of Care.com, haushaltshilfe24.at operates predominantly in the DACH-region in Central Europe. Both platforms exhibit highly comparable characteristics in terms of user interface design, service offerings, and business models, offering a subscription-based online marketplace that focuses on mediation, leaving the working conditions and payment to be negotiated between clients and cleaners.

² This paper is part of the research project TICS (see acknowledgements) and its ethics committee approval; informed consent was obtained for all interviews.

the platform, similar to the recruitment of cleaners, generated only very limited response.

Interview transcripts were inductively coded in MaxQDA—a process followed by refining preliminary categories into recurrent core themes. When constructing the condensed composite vignettes, we focused on these recurrent themes and analyzed them in relation to the mutual experiences of clients and cleaners (i.e., online and offline micro-politics), as well as the domestic workers' positions within broader societal structures. When writing the vignettes, we merged paraphrased accounts with selected quotations (marked in the vignettes by quotation marks) to produce fictionalized yet empirically grounded narratives (see Fig. 1).

Composite vignettes have recently emerged as a valuable methodological approach in qualitative research, particularly within fields that seek to capture lived experiences in nuanced, evocative, and accessible ways. Unlike traditional thematic analyses, which often rely on decontextualized quotations, composite vignettes synthesize participants' narratives into short, fictionalized stories that represent the collective experiences of multiple participants while remaining grounded in the interview material. As a result, they bring thematic patterns to life; they are “fictional in form yet factual in content” (Smith et al., 2016, cited in Crocker et al., 2021, p. 3), as they use invented story elements and composite characters to embody recurring themes and challenges identified during analysis. As described in several recent studies (Claeys et al., 2025; Crocker et al., 2021; Dikmans et al., 2025; Knight et al., 2023), this technique is situated at the intersection of narrative inquiry and creative nonfiction, which offers both epistemological and practical benefits for researchers and their audiences.

Epistemologically, composite vignettes align with constructivist frameworks. As Crocker et al. (2021) emphasized, qualitative interpretation is co-constructed by the researchers and participants, shaped by the researchers' positionalities and experiential knowledge. Vignettes reflect this stance by acknowledging that findings are not neutral reproductions of data but interpretive representations.

Similarly, Claeys et al. (2025) emphasized that composite vignettes are particularly useful in studies aiming to amplify the voices of marginalized individuals or portray experiences that may otherwise be silenced. Rather than reproducing individual accounts, the method merges multiple voices into a cohesive narrative that reflects shared experiences and patterns. Hence, composite vignettes move beyond the mere illustration of findings to become interpretive products that reveal the essence of the participants' perspectives in an engaging, relatable manner. Moreover, this method captures the complexity of shared experiences without oversimplifying or fragmenting them into isolated themes to offer a more holistic account (Knight et al., 2023). Finally, composite vignettes as an analytical tool align with our above-mentioned focus on reflexivity and ethical engagement. By fictionalizing composite characters, researchers can protect participant anonymity while still presenting their emotional experiences and reflections, along with their own reflections.

5. When clients and cleaners meet: Condensed composite vignettes of offline experiences with online mediation

The advent of labor platforms offers both cleaners and clients easier access to ‘dirty work’. This is especially attractive for cleaners with limited social networks due to recent migration to Austria, as well as the promise of additional and flexible work opportunities. For clients, easier access refers to the seemingly convenience of online mediation without face-to-face negotiations. In the following, we first focus on the clients' perspectives on finding a cleaner online and communicating their expectations both via the platform and during the initial encounter, before turning to the cleaners' viewpoints to illustrate how they experience the platform, perceive and anticipate clients' expectations, and respond to them in the first cleaning gigs.

5.1. Clients: Choosing a cleaner on the platform

Clients are faced with an abundance of cleaner profiles in the app (or a similar digital display). Each offers a glimpse of the person behind the service. Choosing a cleaner involves assessing these digital representations for trustworthiness, compatibility, and reliability, while anticipating how the person may fit into the rhythms, routines, and rules of the home. The first vignette illustrates how clients navigate these impressions in practice.

We³ find ourselves scrolling slowly through the profiles on the platform, feeling slightly overwhelmed by the sheer number of cleaners, unsure how to find the right one, pausing at those that seemed to reveal something of the person behind them. Even more than professional qualifications, we want to feel that she⁴ would fit in, that she would be comfortable in our space, and we would be comfortable with her. “We think it is a bit of sympathy. And some of them just radiate this domesticity, as if they just know what's important at home.” Profiles that feel personal, warm, or individual stand out, while we quickly swipe away those that feel impersonal or template-style.

“We do not care whether she is Austrian,” but it is yet important that we can understand each other in a literal and figurative sense without too much effort, because otherwise it would be hard to explain what needs to be done. For us, “it is not that important that the person has some kind of professional training. We actually agree on this: if someone offers a service, then we believe this person will want to do a good job.” A display of professionalism is thus also important, so just for us to be sure she takes her job seriously. “You can see that in the pictures; many of them are really problematic, we have to say. They don't look particularly professional but rather display private holiday selfies.” And yet, a profile could refer to years of cleaning experiences, but still, if it feels cold or too distant, we move on. And we feel similar about the reviews: “We think the rest is gut feeling. ... I don't think we pay much attention to the reviews, but rather to whether she seems nice, whether we feel like we would happily let her into our flat.”

We also value reliability and stability, particularly because we want someone who could become part of our weekly routine, “and does not disappear after two weeks.” But, we are not overly concerned about finding a suitable cleaner right away, because the platform definitely takes the stress of looking for one off our shoulders. There are so many cleaners available! If it does not work out, “we just move on to the next person on our favorites list.”

5.2. Clients: Communicating expectations

Once a cleaner is chosen, the next step is determining how the work will be conducted. Clients negotiate tasks, wages, time schedules, and personal boundaries with cleaners while using the platform as a space to communicate expectations before bringing someone into their home. The following vignette shows how these negotiations unfold in practice, both online and during the initial offline encounters within the clients' homes.

We sat down together before registering on the platform, discussing “how often we want the cleaner to come, which tasks she should perform, which rooms she should clean, and how much we are willing to pay,” and then we placed our job description on the platform accordingly. So, when we find a cleaner profile we like, we communicate these expectations via the platform chat, and if we mutually agree, we invite her for a trial cleaning of our flat.

We are always a bit nervous before these meetings, “Would she fit into our household?” “At the beginning, we only say generally what should be done, and then we watch how she works.” Usually, we point out the main tasks and places: bathroom, kitchen, floors, and explain where all cleaning supplies are stored, and then see how she handles it, “whether she pays attention.” If she

³ We use the collective “we” to mirror the clients' own mode of speaking, as most referred to their household or family through a shared voice when describing their experiences.

⁴ We intentionally use female pronouns here to reflect and make visible how clients collectively imagine and address cleaners as women in their narratives.

Steps for Creating Composite Vignettes

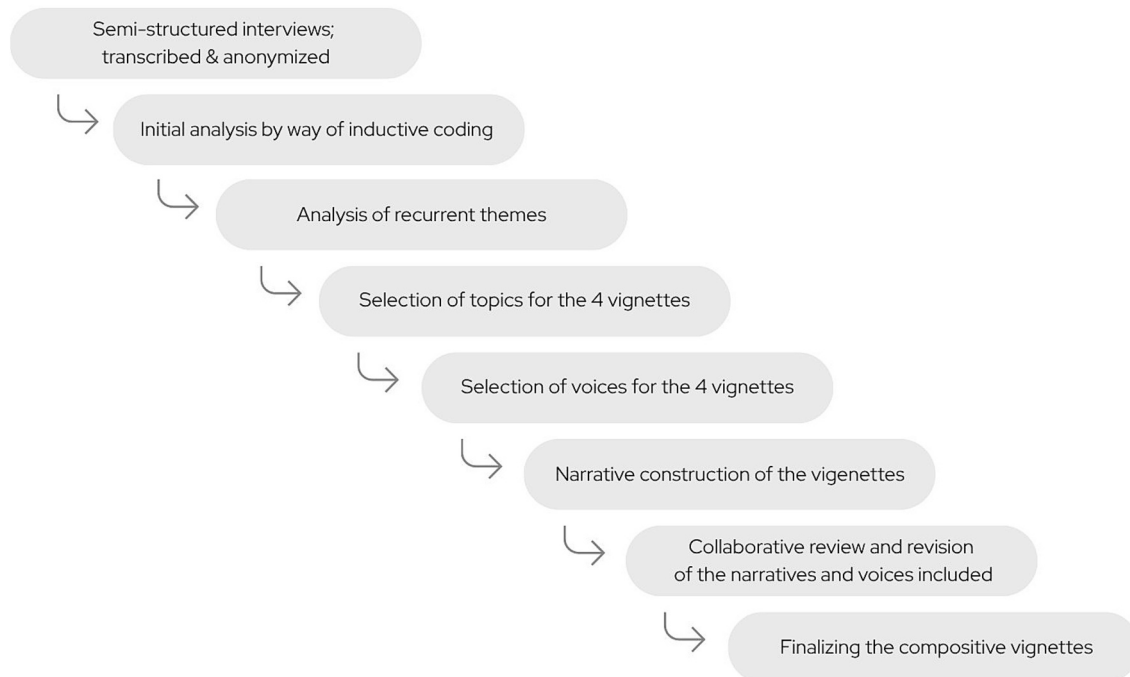


Fig. 1. Summary of the steps for the production of composite vignettes (authors' rendering based on the methodological descriptions by [Claeys et al., 2025](#), and [Crocker et al., 2021](#)).

asks questions right away, when she displays experience and is proactive about the tasks at hand, it reassures us. We do not have the time or the energy to explain tasks over and over again, so we value if she has an eye for what needs to be done today or can be postponed, like descaling the shower or cleaning the fridge, because next to the cleaning work as such, "it simply relieves us of so much mental work."

However, regardless of how well she cleans, if she is not showing initiative or we feel like we do not get along with her on a personal level, we do not ask her to come again. It is still our home, and having them there and feeling uncomfortable in our own flat will simply not work. For example, "There was one who was so judgmental about how messy it was, that really didn't work for us at all." So, we decided to continue looking for someone who "makes our lives easier," even though, admittedly, finding the right person is not as easy as the platform advertises.

5.3. Cleaners: Detecting expectations online

While clients can enjoy the platform's affordances by browsing, comparing, selecting, and rejecting cleaners without much consequence, cleaners experience the platform remarkably differently. They spend (unpaid) time curating their online profiles to convey trustworthiness, competence, female sensibility, and domesticity to appeal to a broad range of clients. Moreover, the platform interface and clients offer minimal information about themselves, their expectations, and the tasks at hand. The subsequent vignette lends voice to this perspective by illustrating how cleaners present themselves to attract clients while navigating the uncertainties and vulnerabilities associated with the digital mediation of platform work.

I put loads of effort into curating my profile on the platform. It's important because you want to appeal to as many clients as possible. "In my profile, I have a professional picture, not just some selfie ... with good make-up and a blouse. Since I did that, clients take me more seriously." I also mention that I am a housewife and mother, because people trust you more easily, they think, she has children, she knows how to manage a household. Still, being a mother actually means not that one can clean perfectly by nature, ... though clients

often see it that way. So, I put something about how important a clean home is to me in addition to all the other information in the profile. These include, for example, emphasizing "that I speak German fluently, ... so they don't think I'm some lazy migrant." And I put stuff about my hobbies, for example I like to hike and exercise, and that I do not smoke, so they know I am fit, physically able to do the job and will not leave their home smoke-filled.

When they message me and I feel like they seem friendly and respectful, then I agree to the job and will try my best to show them I'm the right fit for them. But this is not easy, because I really do not get many information about them, their home, or what they expect. "I have to upload my picture, my full name, I have to present everything. The clients, however, they sometimes really hide everything about themselves." Many job postings or messages are extremely short, just "Need cleaning, two hours," and you don't know at all what's behind it. It's all a guessing game. Others start right away with bargaining the fee: "So, you'll do it cheaper, right? Fifteen euros?" or do not address me as a person at all, "getting straight into negotiating schedules or bargains, without a hello or anything, there really is no respect from some people." And what is more, some of them send really weird messages, asking if I also do massage or could do the cleaning in underwear. ... I don't answer these strange messages. And then you have the ones who write to me every day, late at night, again and again things such as "I imagine that you look good." I am blocking them straight away. So, often you feel it's not about cleaning, but something else. The hardest is when you notice people expect not only that you can do the cleaning, but also good looks, perfect German, and obedient behavior, fitting to their home ... about which they give hardly anything away. "As a woman, and especially as a cleaner, the expectations are pretty clear": you should be polite, friendly, rather reserved, and above all, well, somehow very 'feminine' in your work and in your looks.

5.4. Cleaners: Assessing situations and performing expected roles

The first visit to a client's home is a moment of heightened uncertainty and careful performance. Cleaners must navigate the practical tasks of cleaning, as well as the expectations, moods, and subtle judgments of their clients. Each encounter is shaped by the unspoken power

dynamics of the domestic space: while clients set the rules and standards, cleaners adapt their behavior, appearance, and demeanor to fit the household. The fourth vignette captures these initial meetings by showing how cleaners read atmospheres, anticipate expectations, and manage both emotional and economic pressures during their first encounter in clients' homes.

The first time I go to a client's flat, I'm always a bit nervous because you never know who will open the door, "you never know who and what is coming." I always prepare myself by acting in a way that people think I am organized and obedient. I always feel that I have to fulfill a certain image, mixing politeness with professionalism. So, I'll be extra polite, try to be the person they want me to be. "Like some want a bubbly mom-like person, others want a silent professional blending into the background, so I try to anticipate and match that." I've learned to read the atmosphere during a first encounter quickly. If they show me around kindly, I feel like I can take initiative, maybe even smile and chat a little about their plants or children. If they just give orders, I keep my head down and nod.

Sometimes it works well. They welcome me, show me around, tell me what's most important. "I always ask: what is the priority, what do you want to be done first, where are the cleaning things. And I watch how they talk to me, if it's respectful." But sometimes, it feels more like a test, when the client checks the mirror right after I wiped it, finds one tiny drop and says this is not good enough. Another time, I felt like I was in school again. "The woman watches me the whole time, writing things down in a notebook". And there are the ones who try to turn a cleaning job into something else, invitations, comments, advances. "You learn fast which houses feel safe and which don't."

Still, the money is always in my mind. I am working as a cleaner because I need the money, I have children to support—not because I love cleaning so much. To some homes, I would rather not return, but then I count what's left, particularly at the end of a month. There are bills to pay and food to buy for me and my children. And I know the clients "know that you need the money, and they think you won't say no." So, I swallow my pride, keep smiling, finish the work, agree to the next cleaning appointment, and tell myself I'll look for someone better on the platform along the road.

6. Discussion: Between convenience and control—Platform-mediated encounters of clients and cleaners

The rise of domestic service platforms in Austria and other parts of Continental Europe signals a technological shift and a deeper socioeconomic transformation in how domestic care labor is organized, valued, and experienced. Even though platformization is often framed as an innovation that formalizes previously informal sectors and offers flexible labor opportunities, our empirical findings among others (e.g., Pulignano et al., 2023; Wiesböck et al., 2023), suggest that, in practice, this is rarely the case. Additionally, platformization entrenches preexisting stereotypes and inequalities while disposing of responsibility under the guise of the technology's efficiency and (supposed) neutrality.

At the core of the platform model lies a paradox. While digital platforms claim to professionalize and facilitate cleaning services, they simultaneously obscure the embodied, emotional, and precarious labor that underpins this work. Through the lens of our composite vignettes and including the perspectives of platforms' clients, it becomes clear that platforms rely on and reproduce structural power asymmetries of class, gender, and race/migration by placing the burden of trust-building and affective labor mainly on the shoulders of the cleaners. By contrast, clients retain decision-making power with little oversight or accountability for their relationship with cleaners, e.g., respect and fair pay (see also Altenried & Niebler, 2024; Gerold et al., 2025; Pignolo, 2025).

The overarching questions posed in this paper is whether platforms are "uncaring by design." Drawing on Chatzidakis et al.'s (2020) notion of "carewashing" and Fraser's (2022) critique of "cannibal capitalism," we understand these platforms not as (failed) outcomes of digital innovation but as products of neoliberal and patriarchal logics that place profit over people, commodify domestic care tasks while devaluing the

workers who perform it. The cultivated ethos of care, fostered through cleaners' profile pictures and personal descriptions, is exploited as a tool for platforms to extract profit.

In analyzing interpersonal dynamics between cleaners and clients in the intimate sphere of the home, our interview-based composite vignettes reveal, first of all, that experiences of embodied encounters between cleaners and clients to a certain degree mirror or even manifest broader social structures and hierarchies. It is not platforms' digital technology that is uncaring by design, but platforms rest on and integrate the uncaring character of neoliberal and patriarchal capitalism. Platforms mediating domestic labor have identified the increasing demand for this type of work and built a triangular arrangement that advances the structural devaluation of domestic labor and intensifies the power asymmetries between clients and cleaners at the micro-level of embodied encounters along classed, gendered and migrantized axes. To put it more generally, platforms have recognized the social importance of housework, but are unwilling to recognize this value in terms of respect, formal employment and payment.

Our findings yet do not suggest that technology is irrelevant. Rather, the digital layer amplifies existing structures of inequality. These platforms promote their mediation services with easy access to services, flexibility, and convenience for clients—and with easier access to gigs and income for cleaners. However, the supposed convenience of fast and easy access to an array of cleaners turns out to be not as convenient as promised, as the first two vignettes demonstrate: Clients faced with abundant profiles seek cleaners who 'fit in' with the rhythms and norms of their homes, assessing cleaners not only on qualifications and cleaning competence but also on interpersonal compatibility and initiative. Clients thus still have to make an active choice among cleaner online profiles and invest time (and nerves) in meeting them, in trial and error. What is more, the pre-platform ways of negotiating wages, terms and sympathies remain somewhat the same, including clients' security needs because they let 'strangers' into their home. This fear of 'stranger danger' seems even to have increased, compared to previous recommendations of cleaners among family and friends. The promises of platform-based convenience have therefore raised expectations of ease that cannot be fulfilled. Disappointment with the platforms' intermediary function is then for clients often higher than for workers.

The two vignettes derived from interviews with cleaners explain how the platforms (and the clients) profit from their work—on- and off-line—but these insights are neither new, nor surprising. They confirm the results of previous platform research counting on interviews with workers, for example, that cleaners invest considerable unpaid time curating professional, trustworthy, and feminine profiles to attract clients, while facing minimal information about clients' homes or expectations, making each first encounter fraught with uncertainty and the need to carefully perform expected roles (Gruszka et al., 2024; Wiesböck & Radlherr, 2025). Cleaners must appear as being able to simultaneously perform domesticity, emotional responsiveness, and polite professionalism without a guarantee of income, safety, or respect. They need to deliver online and offline affective labor of sensing clients' demands and dealing with them in an appropriate manner, as well as unpaid work on their profiles—in exchange for unreliable and unprotected gigs. What is more, cleaners are fully exposed online (e.g., through their names, photographs, biographical information, and language skills), while clients and their expectations remain hidden. This invisibility reinforces a power imbalance, as cleaners must constantly anticipate and conform to unspoken expectations. As the cleaners' vignettes illustrate, this asymmetry opens the door to microaggressions, racism, and even sexual provocation. Because of the anonymity of platform mediation, some clients even seem to have less qualms about wage dumping, relegating the cleaners while observing their work or asking for services other than cleaning. These risks are amplified by the privatized nature of the workspace—in the client's home—and the absence of protective oversight by the platform or any other third party.

Platform mediation therefore undermines the affective relationships

that are often central to domestic labor. By removing relational negotiation from the initial hiring process and replacing it with online reviews and impersonal metrics such as rating scores, platforms abstract domestic service labor from its context and reduce workers to disposable service units. As Piletić (2024) noted, while platforms may perpetuate neoliberal developments, they also reconfigure the modes and relations of social reproduction by outsourcing affective labor to digital systems that do not recognize or reward it.

Moreover, the concept of “infrastructured bodies” (Lesutis & Kaika, 2024) helps to illuminate how workers' gendered, racialized/migrantized, and classed embodiments are transformed into functional components of the urban care infrastructure, that are simultaneously indispensable and invisible. In our vignettes, the cleaners described the pressure to appear competent, cheerful, and feminine while navigating linguistic barriers and fearing being rated poorly or harassed. This affective performance, while unpaid and unrecognized, is crucial to maintaining access to future gigs. Yet, platform mediation also results in clients' affective effort—as they are faced with a ‘catalogue’ of cleaner profiles, enabling rapid comparison and disposability of cleaners (see Pignolo, 2025 for this “catalogue effect”). Clients can scroll through numerous profiles and swipe to dispose of them, hire them with minimal commitment, or switch workers at will. But they still have to see if the cleaners are a good fit for their household.

Hence, domestic service labor platforms capitalize on these labor dynamics enabled by technology without assuming any responsibility. Instead, they frame themselves as neutral intermediaries while shifting liability to clients and workers. This organizational structure makes it nearly impossible for workers to collectively bargain, form solidarity networks, or even identify their fellow workers. It is a continuation of what Bridget Anderson (1997, p. 37) described as domestic labor being “at once badly regarded and extremely important”—a foundational contradiction that persists in the gig economy and thus can be read as “old wine in new bottles” (Milkman, 2020).

Contrary to dominant narratives of platform managers that emphasize innovation and the empowerment of both clients and cleaners (for details, see Lentz et al., 2025), our findings highlight the continuity between platform-mediated domestic services and established regimes of feminized and migrantized domestic care work. As Nancy Fraser (2016, 2022), Silvia Federici (2019, 2020), and Kathi Weeks (2011) argued, capitalism has always depended on the unpaid or underpaid labor of women—especially migrant women—to reproduce labor power and secure basic needs at home. Platforms simply extend this logic into digital space by commodifying time, emotions, and availability while obscuring responsibility and intensifying precarity.

Therefore, the technology is neither neutral nor the problem; the issue is how it is embedded within and exploited by neoliberal structures of patriarchal capitalism. Due to the increased need of many households for dual incomes and for women entering the labor force in Europe, domestic tasks such as cleaning have been shifted to ‘other’ women of different classes and ethnic groups. When platform-mediated, in Austria and many other European countries, this shift remains part of the informal economy. However, once again, it is a gendered division of domestic labor that speaks to a “subtle patriarchy” (Leonard, 2001, p. 74; see also Fraser, 2016).

Our findings, however, hint at a reconceptualization of platform urbanism: Its focus on the co-constitutive relationship between platforms and public urban life so far excludes private spaces and homes—though they are obviously parts of urban space incorporated by platforms (Leszczynski, 2020). Platforms mediating domestic cleaning and other types of care work depend on and capitalize on the commodification of social reproduction. They thereby manifest the invisibility and devaluation of domestic labor and also manifest—to a certain extent—the division of public and private spheres and the gendered power asymmetries associated with these spheres. On the one hand, the public–private divide is manifested by platforms mediating gigs in urban space. This division, on the other hand, is also manifested

by research on platform urbanism as long as its focus is solely on the public urban space in a traditional sense (for an extended critique, see Bauriedl & Striver, 2020).

7. Conclusions and outlook

In conclusion, we consider it essential to stress that cleaners' material, physical, and emotional exploitation via platforms is not inherent to digital mediation per se; it stems from preexisting patriarchal and capitalist norms that devalue social reproduction and domestic care, feminized and affective labor, and migrant workers. Therefore, we expand on the following statement by Niels van Doorn (2017, p. 907–908): “In the world of platform labor, inequality is a feature rather than a bug. Platform labor remains thoroughly embedded in a world created by the capitalist value form, which hinges on the gendered and racialized subordination of low-income workers, the unemployed, and the unemployable.” We contend that it is not a feature of the platform but rather of platform *capitalism* and *neoliberal* capitalism as social order that are inherently uncaring by design (Chatzidakis et al., 2020; Fraser, 2022; Srnicek, 2017). The existence of non-exploitative, worker-owned/governed labor platforms and platform cooperatives are a prominent testimonial of this (Micken et al., 2024; Staubli, 2025; Vallas & Schor, 2020).

In this paper, we argued that the challenges faced by domestic cleaners in Austria's platform economy are not simply byproducts of digital innovation but rooted in deeper structures of inequality. The platformization of domestic service labor—far from disrupting the exploitative conditions of informal domestic care work—has rearticulated them in new and, in many ways, more subtle and sinister forms. Under the guise of convenience and flexibility, platforms impose new burdens on already marginalized workers, especially migrant women, while protecting clients and platform companies from responsibility.

We disclosed that these platforms function as providers of embodied infrastructures of social reproduction (Berfelde & Kluzik, 2022; Zampoukos et al., 2024) in the private sphere of the home and thus beyond public urban space (Bauriedl & Striver, 2020, 2022; Striver, 2024). Moving beyond the digital platform to include clients' perspectives and offline encounters between clients and cleaners, the analysis revealed that it is embodied labor and racialized/migrantized, classed, and gendered bodies that become infrastructured by (platform) capitalism, as they are both exploited and disposable (see Lesutis & Kaika, 2024, p. 465 for an analogy independent from platform research). Thus, gendered, migrantized, and classed platform-mediated cleaning labor is an embodied infrastructure that secures domestic social reproduction in an increasingly asymmetrical way. Indeed, labor platforms utilize cleaners' curated profiles and clients' review systems to commodify domestic care and affective labor, which transfers the risks and responsibilities of labor onto cleaners, who must navigate physical tasks and emotional performance while facing the fear of harassment. Our composite vignettes reveal how power asymmetries manifest in everyday experiences, both online and offline, in clients' private homes—but yet need to be considered as part of the urban (Blunt & Sheringham, 2018) and as crucial part of platform urbanism.

Moving forward, research must look more intensively beyond the surface of platform and app design to confront the structural conditions that shape it. Efforts to improve labor protections, formalize domestic labor to some extent, and foster collective organizing among workers are but one of the ways forward. It is equally important to engage in an ongoing and more comprehensive discussion of how social reproduction is re-privatized (in both a social and spatial sense) and increasingly neglected—how it is valued and devalued—in the household due to collective and individual time pressure in today's capitalist societies. Care and reproductive labor must at last be recognized as collective responsibilities rather than individualized market transactions—otherwise platform-mediated domestic service labor will

continue to expose the uncaring core of neoliberal capitalism. The embodied and affective labor of cleaners is not peripheral to this system but constitute its very infrastructure, sustaining a social order that inherently depends on the privatization, exploitation, invisibilization and devaluation of feminized, racialized/migrantized, and classed domestic labor.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Anke Strüver: Writing – original draft, Visualization, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Janne Martha Lentz:** Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Helena Bellgardt:** Formal analysis.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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